Daily life is guided by water clocks—i.e., water-filled copper vessels with calibrated holes—and distinct drum beats at different hours or the blowing of conch shells. Gongs signal the start and end of events, services and ceremonies. To get some exercise, all monks take walks in mid-mornings or late afternoons.



Figure 5. The entrance to a monastery

In late afternoons or early evenings, monks join a three-part prayer service. Buddhist priests perform this service at the temple, walking *Figure 5. The entrance to a monastery* ‘three times round a stupa, offering incense and flowers. They kneel down, and one of them who sings well begins to chant hymns’, extolling the Buddha ‘with a melodious, pure, and sonorous voice, and continues to sing ten or twenty slokas’. Additional hymns and slokas from scripture are recited. Many of these ‘charming compositions’ contain ‘high principles’ and are the work of Matriketa, a ‘great literary talent’. He lived long ago, writes Yijing, but is so revered that ‘all who compose hymns imitate his style, considering him the father of literature’. As the ceremony ends, the assembled monks cry out, ‘*Subhashita*! *Sadhu*! [Well spoken! Well done!].’ Because Nalanda’s population is too large to